

42 Joshua

Moses' faithful servant who led Israel across the Jordan and into the promised land.

Joshua spent forty years in Moses' shadow before he led the nation. He fought Amalek, waited on the mountain while Moses met God, and stayed near the tent of meeting. As a spy he trusted God's promise when ten others spread fear, and he was one of only two adults of his generation to enter Canaan. After Moses died, God told him to be strong and of a good courage. Joshua led Israel through the Jordan, saw Jericho fall, won the land and divided it, and in old age called the people to choose whom they would serve.

At a glance

Name	Yehoshua, "the LORD is salvation"; first Oshea
Family	Son of Nun, of the tribe of Ephraim (Numbers 13:8)
When	Entry into Canaan c. 1406 BC (late-date view c. 1220 BC)
Roles	Moses' minister, spy, army commander, Moses' successor
Key places	Rephidim, Sinai, Kadesh, the Jordan, Jericho, Ai, Shechem
Key people	Moses, Caleb, Eleazar the priest, Rahab, Achan
Death	Age 110; buried at Timnath-serah (Joshua 24:29–30)
New Testament	Acts 7:45; Hebrews 4:8 (KJV "Jesus"); Hebrews 11:30

"Have not I commanded thee? Be strong and of a good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the LORD thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest."

Joshua 1:9, KJV

The life of Joshua

Dates follow the early Exodus date (c. 1446 BC); on the late date, the entry is c. 1220 BC. Scripture gives Joshua's age only at his death.

c. 1446 BC <i>At Rephidim</i>	Defeats Amalek Joshua leads the fighting men while Moses holds up his hands on the hill. <i>Exodus 17:8-16</i>
c. 1446 BC <i>At Sinai</i>	Moses' servant A "young man" who "departed not out of the tabernacle." <i>Exodus 24:13; 32:17; 33:11</i>
c. 1445 BC <i>At Kadesh</i>	One of the spies With Caleb he urges Israel to trust God, and the people want to stone them. <i>Numbers 13:1-16; 14:6-10, 30</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>Plains of Moab</i>	Commissioned Moses lays hands on him, and he is "full of the spirit of wisdom." <i>Numbers 27:18-23; Deuteronomy 31:7-8; 34:9</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>At the Jordan</i>	Crosses over The waters stop for the ark, and Israel crosses on dry ground to Gilgal. <i>Joshua 3:1-5:12</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>Jericho and Ai</i>	First victories Jericho's walls fall; after Achan's sin, Ai is taken at the second attempt. <i>Joshua 6:1-8:29</i>
c. 1400 BC (rough) <i>Years of war</i>	The land is taken He defeats the southern and northern kings and divides the land. <i>Joshua 10-11; 14:6-10; 18:1-10</i>
Age 110 <i>At Shechem</i>	Covenant and death He renews the covenant, then dies and is buried in his inheritance. <i>Joshua 24:1-31</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Caleb's ages (40 at the spying, 85 at the division) suggest about 45 years between (Joshua 14:7, 10).

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- 1 Fought Amalek.** He fought while Moses prayed, and the victory was rehearsed "in the ears of Joshua." *Exodus 17:9-14*

 - 2 Served Moses.** He learned to lead by first learning to follow. *Exodus 24:13; 33:11*

 - 3 Guarded Moses' honour.** He asked Moses to forbid Eldad and Medad; Moses wished all were prophets. *Numbers 11:26-29*

 - 4 Gave a faithful report.** He and Caleb said the land was "exceeding good" and urged the people not to fear. *Numbers 14:6-9*

 - 5 Received his charge.** Moses laid hands on him, and God told him to be strong and courageous and to keep the book of the law. *Deuteronomy 31:7-8; Joshua 1:1-9*

 - 6 Crossed the Jordan.** He set up twelve stones at Gilgal so children would ask what they meant. *Joshua 4:1-7, 19-24*

 - 7 Met the captain of the host.** Near Jericho he fell down and took off his shoes. *Joshua 5:13-15*

 - 8 Took Jericho.** He followed God's unusual battle plan and spared Rahab and her family. *Joshua 6:1-25*

 - 9 Dealt with Achan.** After the defeat at Ai, he sought God and brought hidden sin into the open. *Joshua 7:6-26*

 - 10 Was deceived by Gibeon.** He made a treaty without asking "counsel at the mouth of the LORD," but he kept his word. *Joshua 9:3-27*

 - 11 Prayed for the sun to stand still.** At Gibeon he said, "Sun, stand thou still upon Gibeon." Christians read this as a miracle in different ways. *Joshua 10:12-14*

 - 12 Called Israel to choose.** At Shechem he declared, "as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD." *Joshua 24:14-27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joshua.

Old Testament

Numbers 27:15–23; Deuteronomy 34:9	Moses hands leadership to him
Joshua 1–24	The conquest and division of the land
Joshua 21:43–45	"There failed not ought of any good thing"
Judges 2:6–9	Israel served the LORD all the days of Joshua
1 Kings 16:34	His curse on Jericho's rebuilder comes true
Tradition	The Talmud says Joshua wrote most of his book; it names no author

New Testament

Acts 7:45	The tabernacle came in "with Jesus," meaning Joshua
Hebrews 4:8	"If Jesus had given them rest"; again Joshua
Hebrews 11:30	"By faith the walls of Jericho fell down"
Echo: Hebrews 4:9–11	"Jesus" is the Greek form of Joshua

For discussion

- Observe:* How many times does God tell Joshua to be strong and courageous (Joshua 1:1–9)?
- Understand:* Why do you think Joshua spent so many years as Moses' servant?
- Apply:* What reminders of God's help could you share with someone younger?
- Apply:* "Choose you this day." What choice about serving God is in front of you?